Prodigal Son

By Garrison Keillor

INTRODUCTION

A happy day, a sunny street, you're young and in love and life is good and you're on your way to lunch, when suddenly a cold shadow falls and (Loathsome laugh.) you feel a cold slimy hand touch your face. (Worse laugh.) And it's your own hand. (Worst laugh.) That's evil. Where does evil come from? Whose fault is it? The American Council of Remorse-a nonprofit organization working for greater contrition on the part of people who do terrible things brings you: The Prodigal Son by Garrison Keillor

DAD: I run a feed-lot operation here in Judea, fattening feeder calves for the Jerusalem market, in partnership with my two sons: my prodigal son, WALLY, and my older son, DWIGHT. One morning about two years ago, I came down to breakfast and-no WALLY. Morning, DWIGHT.

DWIGHT: *(Sitting at table, reading newspaper.)* Morning.

DAD: You see your brother this morning?

DWIGHT: In bed.

DAD: I promised Harry Shepherd I'd be over to his place by seven-thirty. He's got a lost sheep out on the mountain wild and steep.

DWIGHT: Says here that fatted calves are down one and three-quarter shekels on the Damascus market, DAD. Makes me wonder if maybe lean calves wouldn't have a higher profit margin, and then we could spend more time in the vineyard- DAD, are you listening to me?

DAD: I'm worried about your brother.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DWIGHT: We can't afford to stand still, DAD. Look at the Stewarts they're buying up land left and right! You've got to move ahead or you lose ground. . . .

WALLY: *(Thickly.)* Morning, DAD. Morning, DWIGHT. *(He sits down, groans, puts his head in his hands.)*

DAD: You look a little peaked, son.

WALLY: I donno-it's some kind of morning sickness, DAD. I feel real good at night and then I wake up and hurt all over.

DWIGHT: I noticed a couple empty wineskins behind the fig tree this mormng.

WALLY: I dropped them and they spilled! Honest!

DAD: Where were you taking them?

WALLY: I was putting them outside! Wine's got to breathe, you know. And so do I, DAD. I've got a real breathing problem here. I'm worried about my health, DAD. I read an article the other day in Assyrian Digest that says bad feelings may be environmental. I donno. Maybe I need to get away for a while, DAD. Get my head straight. Work out some things.

DAD: Well, if that's how you feel, I guess I . . .

WALLY: I was thinking I'd sort of take my share of the farm and head for a far country for a while until I get back on my feet, headwise, and then come back a brand-new guy.

DWIGHT: DAD, could we discuss this?

NARRATOR: And not many days after, the younger son gathered his inheritance together, and took his journey into a far country. . . .

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

WALLY: *(Walking.)*

I'm walkin' . . . to a far-out land.

I'm talkin' . . . got cash in hand.

I'm hot now. . . don't you understand.

You're lookin' at a brand-new man. *(FOOLISH VIRGINS enter, harnessed together, led by a WISE VIRGIN.)*

Hey! Who's this? Hey. What's shakin', babes?

WISE: I'm taking these five foolish virgins home, mister. We were supposed to be at a wedding an hour ago, but they're low on oil. You see an oil station that way?

WALLY: Hey, they don't look foolish to me. They look like kinda fun people. Tell you what, they can come with me. I'll buy them oil. My treat.

WISE: Sorry, mister. I've got to look after these virgins myself. They take a lot of supervision. You gotta watch 'em pretty close so they don't bunch up and walk up each other's backs. *(Crash.)*

WALLY: Whoops-dropped your lamp, huh? Good thing it didn't have oil in it. Well, 'bye! Don't do anything I wouldn't do.

We're movin' . . . down the ole highway.

We're improvin' . . . every day.

We're groovin' . . . and we're okay.

NARRATOR: And he took his journey into a far country, and there wasted his substance in riotous living. . . . *(Enter LOOSE COMPANIONS, dancing, drinking, feasting, whooping. BIMBO on WALLY'S arm.)*

WALLY: Take it off! Take it all off! Go for it! Put it on and take it off again! *(To audience.)* Hey, you Pharisees, loosen up

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

BIMBO: You're such a wonderful, vital person.

WALLY: *(To "Hey Jude. ")*

Hey, Judea-you're a real great place.

You're the best spot in the Bi-i-i-ible. . . .

You're right there by Canaan and Galilee,

You're family, you're tribal.

Hey, PUBLICAN! Another round of wine for my pals! Put it on my tab!

Phhhh! Blaaaaghhhhh! What is this??? Lite wine?

PUBLICAN: You don't like it?

WALLY: Give it to some virgins-and bring me your best.

PUBLICAN: I'll give you a jar to take with you-it's closing time. Time to lock up, Mr. WALLY.

WALLY: Hey! I'll pay. Let's party!

BIMBO: Oh, WALLY! You're so joyful! So many persons with a farm back ground, they don't know how to let go and have a good time.

WALLY: Not me, Wanda! Life is a feast if you know where to find it.

PUBLICAN: Here's your bill, Mr. WALLY.

BIMBO: That's so beautiful: "Life is a feast." So many people-they place such restrictions on themselves. *(He reads bill, page after page, then searches his pockets and brings out a few coins.)* You have a better sense of who you are. You have that rare quality of trusting yourself. Believing in festivity, not negativity. In a smile, not denial. Sure, rules are good for people who need 'em. But you prefer freedom. You have this tremendous-this great- It's not a structured thing. You know? Your energy is so focused. Like a locust.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

WALLY: That's the last of my money. That's all I have left. Amazing.

PUBLICAN: You all right? You need a ride home?

WALLY: No.

BIMBO: WALLY-listen. It's been great. Three of the best weeks of my life. Bye. *(The BIMBO, the PUBLICAN, and the LOOSE COMPANIONS leave, one by one.)*

NARRATOR: And when he had spent all, there arose across a mighty famine in that land, and he began to be in want. And he went and lived with a FARMER who sent him into his fields to feed swine.

FARMER: You ever feed swine before?

WALLY: No, but I fed calves. You just dump the husks and swill down in front of them, right?

FARMER: Lot more to it than that. Usually we require swine feeders to have at least four years of professional experience. But tell you what-I'll put you in my internship program.

WALLY: What does it pay?

FARMER: Pay! I'm offering you a chance to learn the swine business from the mud up.

WALLY: SO, you mean I'll sleep out here and eat with the pigs?

FARMER: You want it or not?

WALLY: Fine. Just want to get it clear in my own mind, that's all. C'mon, hogs. Sooo-eyyy! C'mon. C'mon, piggy, piggy, piggy.

NARRATOR: And when he came to himself, he said:

WALLY: How many hired servants of my father's have bread enough and to spare, and I perish with hunger! I will arise and go to my father, and

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

will say unto him: "Father, I have sinned against heaven and before thee, and am no more worthy to be called thy son: make me as one of thy hired servants." No, that doesn't sound good. I will arise and go to my father and will say unto him, "Father, it was a great learning experience, and now I'm back, looking for an entry level position- No. I will arise and go to my father and will say unto him, "Hi, DAD, how you been? Oh, I'm fine. Had a good trip. Say, you got anything to eat around here?"

NARRATOR: And he arose and came to his father. And when he was yet a great way off, his father saw him, and had compassion on him, and ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him. . ..

DAD: WALLY! Son! Oh, WALLY! *(He shouts offstage.)* Bring some clothes! And a ring! And some shoes! And not those running shoes! The dress shoes! And make that two rings!

WALLY: I spent all the money, DAD.

DAD: And bring the fatted calf-let's eat and be merry! My son who was dead is alive again; he was lost and now he is found. Amazing!

WALLY: Mind if I invite some friends too? *(The FOOLISH VIRGINS enter, roped together.)* I met them on the road. They're okay people once you get to know them.

DAD: More rings! More shoes! Another fatted calf! You look good. You look like you've lost weight.

WALLY: I've been on a high-husk diet.

DAD: DWIGHT! Look who's here! It's WALLY!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DWIGHT: *(Enters reluctantly.)* Hi. Nice to see you. *(His DAD turns to WALLY, and DWIGHT shakes both his fists and sticks out his tongue and makes a vulgar gesture.)*

DAD: We're having veal tonight, DWIGHT! WALLY's home.

WALLY: I'm going to go get some of that calf, DAD. Be right back.

DWIGHT: DAD, I don't want this to sound negative in any way, but-how many years have I been working here?

DAD: All your life.

DWIGHT: Have I ever disobeyed you, DAD?

DAD: Never.

DWIGHT: And have you ever given me a fatted calf and thrown a big party for me and my friends?

DAD: No, but, son

DWIGHT: But the minute this bozo comes hoofing it home-this leaker

DAD: But your brother was dead and he's alive again! He was lost and now he's found!

DWIGHT: I don't think you're hearing what I'm saying, DAD. You never ran up to me and hugged me- I'd just like to point that out.

DAD: I'm not a hugger, I guess.

WALLY: *(Enters, mouth full.)* Have some calf, you guys. That fat won't keep, you know. Sure is good fatted calf, DAD. Sure beats husks. *(Off)* Care for another piece, you virgins?

DWIGHT: Ever stop to think who fatted that calf, WALLY? That was our best calf, DAD. The best one. *(The others slowly leave, talking among themselves.)* Try to think how I feel. I'm hoeing corn all day, come in

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

bone-tired, there's my brother smelling of pig manure, and they got the beer on ice and my calf on the barbecue! And MY RING on his hand! My ring! You promised it to me, but oh no-can't give it to the son who's worked his tail off for thirty years, oh no, gotta give it to the weasel who comes dragging his butt in the door- Oh great. Wonderful, DAD. Terrific. Maybe I'll go sleep with the pigs, seeing as you go for that. See ya later, WALLY. Help yourself to the rest of my stuff-clothes, jewels, shekels, just take what you want. Take my room. Don't worry about me. I'll be in the pigpen. *(He leaves. Offstage sounds: A stove being kicked, muttered curses, pots and pans being thrown, dishes broken.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Garrison Keillor
ISBN: 0880014903
Publisher: Ecco Press
Date(Month/Year): Nov 1999

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier – Dramatic Interpretation

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY